

A summary of Ancient Bengal to Bangladesh

The history of Bengal is intertwined with the history of the broader Indian subcontinent and the surrounding regions of South Asia and Southeast Asia. It includes modern-day Bangladesh and the Indian states of West Bengal, Tripura and Assam's Karimganj district, located in the eastern part of the Indian subcontinent, at the apex of the Bay of Bengal and dominated by the fertile Ganges delta. The region was known to the ancient Greeks and Romans as Gangaridai, a powerful kingdom whose war elephant forces led the withdrawal of Alexander the Great from India. Some historians have identified Gangaridai with other parts of India. The Ganges and the Brahmaputra rivers act as a geographic marker of the region, but also connects the region to the broader Indian subcontinent. Bengal, at times, has played an important role in the history of the Indian subcontinent.

The area's early history featured a succession of Indian empires, internal squabbling, and a tussle between Hinduism and Buddhism for dominance. Ancient Bengal was the site of several major Janapadas (kingdoms), while the earliest cities date back to the Vedic period. A thalassocracy and an entrepôt of the historic Silk Road, ancient Bengal had strong trade links with Persia, Arabia and the Mediterranean that focused on its lucrative cotton muslin textiles. The region was a part of several ancient pan-Indian empires, including the Mauryans and Guptas. It was also a bastion of regional kingdoms. The citadel of Gauda served as capital of the Gauda Kingdom, the Buddhist Pala Empire (eighth to 11th century) and Sena Empire (11th–12th century). This era saw the development of Bengali language, script, literature, music, art and architecture.

The Muslim conquest of the Indian subcontinent absorbed Bengal into the medieval Islamic and Persianate worlds. Between the 1204 and 1352, Bengal was a province of the Delhi Sultanate. This era saw the introduction of the taka as monetary currency, which has endured into the modern era. An independent Bengal Sultanate was formed in 1352 and ruled the region for two centuries, during which a distinct form of Islam based on Sufism and the Bengali language emerged and the region was known as a major trading nation in the world. The ruling elite also turned Bengal into the easternmost haven of Indo-Persian culture. The Sultans exerted influence in the Arakan region of Southeast Asia, where Buddhist kings copied the sultanate's governance, currency and fashion. A relationship with Ming China flourished under the sultanate.

The Bengal Sultanate was notable for its Hindu aristocracy, including the rise of Raja Ganesha and his son Jalaluddin Muhammad Shah as usurpers. Hindus served in the royal administration as prime ministers and poets. Under the patronage of Sultans like Alauddin Hussain Shah, Bengali literature began replacing the strong influence of Sanskrit in the region. Hindu principalities included the Kingdom of Mallabhum, Kingdom of Bhurshut and Kingdom of Tripura; and the realm of powerful Hindu Rajas such as Pratapaditya, Kedar Ray and Raja Sitaram Ray.

Following the decline of the sultanate, Bengal came under the suzerainty of the Mughal Empire, as its wealthiest province. Under the Mughals, Bengal Subah rose to global prominence in industries such as textile manufacturing and shipbuilding, its economy in the 18th century exceeding in size any of Europe's empires. This growth of manufacturing has been seen as a form of proto-industrialization, similar to that in western Europe prior to the Industrial Revolution. Bengal's capital Dhaka is said to contained over a million people.

The gradual decline of the Mughal Empire led to quasi-independent states under the Nawabs of Bengal, subsequent to the Maratha invasions of Bengal, and finally the conquest by the British East India Company.

The East India Company took control of the region from the late 18th century. The company consolidated their hold on the region following the battles of Battle of Plassey in 1757 and Battle of Buxar in 1764 and by 1793 took complete control of the region. Capital amassed from Bengal by the East India Company was invested in various industries such as textile manufacturing in Great Britain during the initial stages of the Industrial Revolution. Company policies in Bengal also led to the deindustrialization of the Bengali textile industry during Company rule. Kolkata (or Calcutta) served for many years as the capital of British controlled territories in India. The early and prolonged exposure to the British colonial administration resulted in the expansion of Western-style education, culminating in development of science, institutional education, and social reforms in the region, including what became known as the Bengali Renaissance. A hotbed of the Indian independence movement through the early 20th century, Bengal was partitioned during India's independence in 1947 along religious lines into two separate entities: West Bengal—a state of India—and East Bengal—a part of the newly created Dominion of Pakistan that later became the independent nation of Bangladesh in 1971.

History of Bengal

Stone Age remnants have been found in Bengal that date back 20,000 years. The indigenous population Bengal consists of tribes and of Austric and Austro-Asiatic origin such as Kola, Bhil, Santhal, Shabara, and Pulinda.

Ancient Bengal:

Bengal is a 4,000-year-old civilization that thrived between the banks of Ganges to Brahmaputra and sustained itself with the riches of Gangetic Delta.

Remnants of earliest cities in the state date back to the Vedic Period. The oldest archaeological site in Bangladesh is Mahasthangarh, which dates back to 700 BCE. The culture and ethnicity of Bengal was different than that of the Vedic people. The latter referred to the people of Bengal as 'dasyus' or demons.

Gangaridai

Gangaridai (Greek: Γαγγαρίδαι; Latin: Gangaridae) is a term used by the ancient Greco-Roman writers (1st century BCE-2nd century AD) to describe a people or a geographical region of the ancient Indian subcontinent. Some of these writers state that Alexander the Great withdrew from the Indian subcontinent because of the strong war elephant force of the Gangaridai.

A number of modern scholars locate Gangaridai in the Ganges Delta of the Bengal region, although alternative theories also exist. Gange or Ganges, the capital of the Gangaridai (according to Ptolemy), has been identified with several sites in the region, including Chandraketugarh and Wari-Bateshwar.

The Retreat of Alexander:

Greek traveler and chronicler Megasthenes referred to Bengal as Gangaridai in his book Indica (300 BC). When Alexander invaded India and defeated Porus, he wanted to conquer all of India and moved eastward where he came to know about the mighty forces of the Gangaridai warriors.

Alexander read accounts of Gangetic Delta written by Ptolemy and Diodorus. Greek historian Diodorus Siculus (90 BC -30 BC) depicted the Gangaridai warriors in this manner:

"The river is called the Ganges which had a width of thirty-two stadia, and a greater depth than any other Indian river. Beyond this again were situated the dominions of the nation of the Prasioi and the Gandaridai, whose king, Xandrammes, had an army of 20,000 horses, 200,000 infantries, 2,000 chariots and 4,000 elephants trained and equipped for war.... Now this (Ganges) river, which is 30 stadia broad, flows from north to south, and empties its water into the ocean forming the eastern boundary of the Gandaridai, a nation which possesses the greatest number of elephants and the largest in size."

Arguably, it was the might of the Gangaridai warriors that made Alexander retreat.

Janapads:

For 1000 years, **between 600 BC - 400 BC**, Bengal was politically divided into several Janapads. From the century the names of the Janapada of ancient Bengal were obtained from stone inscriptions and literary works of the Gupta period, post Gupta period, Pala, Sena etc regime. It is not possible to say how much area these Janapadas covered. We can get an idea about their positions from the historical sources of the ancient age. Some Janapads are described below:

Gaur: Though the name Gaur seems familiar, there are many differences of opinions about which area was referred to as Gaur in the ancient time. Again it was also unknown why Gaur was first referred to in the book of Panini. In Kautilya's 'Arthashastra' there are references of many industrial and agricultural products of the country Gaur. In the book of Vatsyana there are also references of the luxurious life of the inhabitants of Gaur in the third and the fourth century. It is proved from the stone inscriptions of the time of Harshavardhana that the country of Gaur was not so far from the coast. From the description written by Varaha Mihira in the sixth century it is seen that Gaur was different from other Janapads such as Pundra, Bengal, Samatata. In Vabishoy Purana it has been described as a region lying on the south of the Padma and on the north of Burdwan. There is much similarity between this comment and the descriptions of the people of the seventh century. In the seventh century the capital of Sasanka, the king of Gaur was Karnasubarna near Murshidabad. Not only Sasanka, in the later periods Gaur was the capital of

many other kings. During Palaa dynasty Gaur had the most name and fame. Then the vast region of north India was included in Gaur. Being a center of the empire, it had irresistible power and strength. In the later periods the destiny of Gaur started to change with the change of the destiny of the Pala empire. Then the border of Gaur diminished. Some regions of present Maldah, Murshidabad, Birbhum and Bardwan were considered the border of Gaur. In the seventh century the capital of the king Sasanka of Gaur was Karnasubarno in the region of Murshidabad. The Lakhnauti in the region of Maldhaha was called Gour at the beginning of the Muslim period. Later, Gaur was meant as the whole of Bengal.

Banga: Bengal was a very ancient Janapada. In the very ancient puthi(fairy tale) it was called neighbor of Janapadas Magodha and Kalinga. It is understandable from the references in Mahabharata that Bengal was a neighboring country of Pundra Tamrolipto and Summa. Descriptions about this Janapada are available in the stone inscriptions of Chandragupta, Vikramaditya, king of Chalukya, Rashtrakuta and in the books of Kalidas. A Janapada named Banga was built to the east and the south-east of present Bangladesh. It is surmised that a nation named Banga lived here. So, the Janapada was familiar as Banga. From the evidence of different sources, it is thought that the area situated between the Ganges and the Bhagirathi was called Banga. The area of Banga shrank during the Pala and the Sena dynasty. In the eleventh century at the last phase of the Pala dynasty, Banga was divided in two parts and they became known as North Banga and South Banga respectively. The Padma was the north border of the northern region and the delta region of the South was the South Banga. In the later periods during the regime of Keshoba Sena and Vishwarup Sena also two parts of Banga were noticed. But now their names were different - one was Vikrampur and the other was Navya. From the old stone inscription, we learn about two parts of Banga. One of them is Vikrampur and the other is Navya. The then Vikrampur comprised of present Vikrampur and some parts of Idilpur Pargana. There is no existence of any place called Navya at present. It is thought that lower marshy places of Faridpur, Barisal, and Patuakhali are included in this Navya region. Banga consisted of greater Bogra, Pabna and western region of Mymensingh, Dhaka, Faridpur, Kushtia, greater Comilla and some parts of Noakhali. The nation 'Bangalee' was originated from 'Banga'.

Pundra: Pundra was one of the most important Janapads of ancient Bengal. It is said that a nation called Pundra built up this Janapada. There are references of this nation in the Vedic literature and in the Mahabharata. Pundranagar was the name of the capital of the Pundras. In later periods, it became known as Mahasthangar. Probably during the reign of the Maurya emperor Ashoka (273-232B.C) ancient Pundra kingdom lost its independent entity. This Pundra kingdom became Pundravardhana with the growth of its prosperity in the fifth - sixth century. Pundravardhana of that time was extended at least across the regions of Bogra, Dinajpur and Rajshahi. Probably the fairly whole north Bengal beginning from Rajmohal-Ganges- Bhagirathi to Korotoa was included in Pundrabardhana during that time. During the Sena reign the most south border of Pundravardhana was extended through the Padma completely to Khari Bishoy (at present Khari Pargona of Chobdigh Parganas) and to the seashore of Dhaka and Barisal. The experts infer that Mahasthangar, seven miles away from Bogra is the ruins of ancient Pundravardhana. It was Pundra which was the most prosperous Janapada of the ancient Bengal from the perspective of evidences of ancient civilization. Probably the most ancient stone inscription inscribed on stone wheel obtained in Bangladesh have been discovered here.

Harikela: The writers of the 7th century have also described another region called Harikela. Chinese traveler Itsing said that Harikela was situated at the end of eastern India. But we can trace parts of present Chittagong in the description of Harikela in the write ups by others. In the analyses of all these data, it can be assumed that Harikela spread from Srihatta (Sylhet) in the east to some portions of Chittagong. Although in the middle was another kingdom named Samatata which can create a little confusion. In fact, loose administration used to prevail in places in the region at that time. Besides, despite Banga, Samatata and Harikela being separate kingdom, sometimes and in some places their identity presumably used to overlap due to their close proximity of borders. Factually, Harikela existed as a separate state from 7th to 8th century to 10th to 11th century A.D. But Harikela was assumed to be a part of Banga since the occupation of Chandradwip by King Trilokyachandra, the descendant of Chandra dynasty in eastern Bengal. Some others are there who assume Sylhet and Harikela to be the same.

Samatata: Samatata was situated in the east and south-east Bengal as a neighboring Jonapada of Banga. This region was a humid low lying land. Some think that Samatata was the ancient name of present Comilla. Again, some other think that Samatata comprised of Comilla and Noakhali region. Present Tripura region was one of the parts of Samatata from the seventh century till the twelfth century. Once upon a time the western border of this Jonapada was extended to the Khari Pargana of Chobish Parganas. The coastal region extending from the eastern shore of Ganges-Bhagirathi to the tributary of the Meghna was probably called Samatata. In the seventh century its capital was the place named Bara Kamta, 12 miles west of Comilla city.

Barendra: Another Jonapada of ancient Bengal could be known in the name of Varendree, Barendra, or Barendra Bhumi. It was also a Janapada of north Bengal. Barendra was the most important region of Pundravardhana Jonapada. Pundravardhana, the main city of the Janapada and the center of the provincial ruler during the Gupta regime, was also in this Barendra region. So, it cannot be called a Janapada. But once upon a time this region used to be introduced by this name. So, in the history of ancient Bengal it was given the dignity of a Janapada. It can undoubtedly be said that this Janapada was situated in region between the Ganges and the Karatoa. The Barendra region was extended across a vast area of Bogra, Dinajpur, and Rajshahi region as well as probably Pabna region.

Tamralipta: Tamralipta Jonapada was situated to the north of Harikela. Tomluk in the region of present Medenipur was the heart of Tamralipta. This coastal area was very humid and low lying. This place was the best for navigational Jonapada. In the ancient time Tamralipta was known to be an important center for river trade. This port stood on the river Rupnarayana, 12 miles away from the juncture of two rivers --- the Hoogly and the Rupnarayana. It started to be known as Dandobhukti since the seventh century. The prosperity of Tamralipta port was damaged just after the eighth century.

Chandradeep: Besides Janapadas mentioned above, there was another tinier Janapada in ancient Bengal. This was Chandradeep. The very Barisal region of today was the mainland

and the heart of Chandradeep. This ancient Jonapadaa was situated in the place between the Baleshwar and the Meghna. Besides, in greater ancient Bengal there were some other Janapadas named Dandobhukti, North Rahr (the western part of present Murshidabad region, whole Birbhum region and Katoa Sub-division of the Budwan region), South Rahr (the southern part of present Budwan, many parts of Hoogly and Howrah region), Bangla (generally Sundarban forests of Khulna, Patuakhali and Barisal) etc.

Thus different parts of ancient Bengal were known by different names from the ancient time till the sixth-seventh century. Basically, it was an economic and geographical division. At the start of the seventh century Sasanka after becoming the king of Gaur organized the total area from Murshidabad to Utkol (North orissa). After that Bengal used to be known by the name of three Janapada. These were Pundravardhana, Banga and Gaur. The existence of the left others was lost in them. Attempts to unite the divided Janapadas reached much of completeness during the regimes of the Pala and the Sena Kings. Though Sasanka and Pala kings were the kings of the whole of West Bengal, they familiarized themselves as 'King of Rahr' or 'King of Gaur'. As a result, the name 'Gaur' gained familiarity. We can get a fair conception of geographical shape, demarcation, political characteristics of the then Bengal from the Janapadas of ancient Bengal. Then there was no political unity in ancient Bengal. The powerful rulers would gain ruling power of more than one Janapada through executing their domination. Thus these Janapadas played roles as the first territorial unit or administrative unit in ancient Bengal and later helped form political unit.

A well-known pre-Aryan kingdom of this region was Gangaridhi or Gangaridai located on the bank of the river Ganges. It was a powerful kingdom in the time when Alexander the Great invaded the North-Western part of India. Besides, the most important Dynasty of Bangladesh “Maurya Dynasty” was established before the advent of the Aryan.